



IELTS Listening Practice Test

Transcript — Parts 1–4 · Episode 8

PART 1

You will hear a telephone conversation between a woman booking a community kitchen and a booking clerk. You now have some time to look at questions 1 to 10.

Speaker B: Good morning, thank you for calling the Elmwood Community Centre. How can I help you today?

Speaker A: Hello, I'd like to book one of your professional kitchens for a cooking workshop we are running.

Speaker B: Certainly, I can help with that. First, let me take down the name of your organization.

Speaker A: Yes, it's the Westby Cooking Club. Oh, wait, sorry, let me correct that, I always write it down wrong. It's actually the Westbury Cooking Club, with an 'r' before the 'y'.

Speaker B: Thank you, I've got that. And can I have a contact phone number for you?

Speaker A: Of course, my mobile is 0-7-9-4-1-8-2-3-5-6.

Speaker B: Let me check that. That's 0-7-9-4-1-8-2-3-5-6?

Speaker A: Yes, that's correct.

Speaker B: Great. Now, what date were you looking to book?

Speaker A: We want to host it on Saturday, October the 14th.

Speaker B: Let me check the schedule... Ah, the 14th is fully booked. We do have Saturday, October the 21st available. Would that work?

Speaker A: Yes, actually, that date is fine. October 21st it is.

Speaker B: Excellent. What time of day would you need the kitchen from?

Speaker A: We want the workshop to start at 10:00 AM, but we need time to set up, so we'd like the booking to start at 9:00 AM.

Speaker B: Perfect, I will reserve it from 9:00 AM. Now, which kitchen room did you want to book? We have the Oak Room, which is smaller, and the Maple Room, which has professional-grade ovens.



Speaker A: We definitely need the professional ovens, so the Maple Room please.

Speaker B: Great. And how many attendees are you expecting?

Speaker A: There will be 12 participants plus 2 instructors, so 14 people in total.

Speaker B: Wonderful. Is there any specific equipment you need us to provide, other than the standard utensils?

Speaker A: We will need a blender. We are making purees, so we really need a high-speed one.

Speaker B: Yes, we have those in our inventory. I'll note down one blender. Are there any food safety restrictions we should be aware of?

Speaker A: Yes, one of our participants has a severe allergy to nuts, so we are keeping the entire event nut-free.

Speaker B: Understood, I'll flag that for the cleaning team so they do a deep sanitize beforehand. Now, about the deposit. Normally, the weekend deposit for the Maple Room is 75 pounds. Oh, wait, let me check that again... actually, because you are a registered community group, you qualify for our discounted rate, so the deposit is only 50 pounds.

Speaker A: That's a nice surprise, 50 pounds is perfect. How should I pay?

Speaker B: I can send you a secure payment link. I'll just need to generate a reference number for your booking first. It's 9-0-3-1-2.

Speaker A: Got it, 9-0-3-1-2. Thank you so much for your help!

Speaker B: You're very welcome. You'll receive the email shortly. Have a great day!

This is the end of Part 1.

PART 2

You will hear a community garden coordinator giving a talk about the development of a local allotment project. You now have some time to look at questions 11 to 20.

Speaker A: Hello everyone, and welcome to the Elmwood Community Garden. My name is John, and I'm the volunteer coordinator here. It's wonderful to see so many new faces today. Let me start by giving you a bit of background about how we got started. Originally, this entire plot of land was just an eyesore—it was an abandoned, overgrown wasteland behind the old public library. A group of local residents got together and decided we wanted to transform this neglected space. While we do now grow fantastic organic vegetables and run educational programs for school children, the primary motivation was simply to clean up and make use of that wasteland. One of our proudest achievements is our irrigation system. Many visitors assume we dug a deep well or that we draw water from the local river. In fact, our water supply is entirely recycled from the sports center next door, where we harvest the rain run-off from their large roof. Now, for those of you who want to get involved, we are always looking for volunteers. You don't need to bring your own tools, as we have plenty of spades and gloves in our shed, and we don't demand a strict commitment—you can work as many or as few hours as you like. However, we do insist that everyone completes a safety induction session before they start. This is a mandatory requirement to ensure everyone knows how to handle the equipment safely. Looking ahead, we have several exciting events coming up. While we enjoyed our harvest festival last autumn, and we are planning a winter cooking exhibition, next month our focus is on art. We are hosting a photography competition where participants can submit photos of the insects and birds that visit our flowers. If you'd like to support us financially, we'd love your help. We can't accept cash donations at the garden gate for security reasons, and we don't have a payment portal on our website yet. Instead, you can support us by purchasing one of our hand-crafted wooden birdhouses. All the money raised goes directly back into buying seeds.

Speaker A: Now, let's talk about some general garden rules and our upcoming development plans. Regarding rules, we are strictly organic here. We don't allow any synthetic fertilizers; instead, all gardeners must use compost to enrich the soil, which you can find in the large bins at the back. Also, while we love animals, dogs can sometimes dig up delicate vegetable beds. Therefore, dogs are allowed, but they must be kept on a leash at all times while inside the garden boundary. Looking to the future, we have some exciting construction projects. This coming winter, we plan to construct a new greenhouse. This will allow us to start seedlings much earlier in the spring. In terms of staffing, we have been run entirely by volunteers so far, but we are growing so fast that we need professional help. Next year, we will recruit a part-time manager to take over the

day-to-day administration and volunteer scheduling. Finally, we want to make the garden more accessible to everyone. We currently have a beautiful central pond, but it's hard for people with limited mobility to get close to it. To solve this, plans are underway to build a wooden bridge over the pond, complete with wheelchair-friendly ramps. This will create a lovely viewing platform.

This is the end of Part 2.



PART 3

You will hear two university students, Helen and Emily, discussing their research project with their tutor, Professor Davis. You now have some time to look at questions 21 to 30.

Speaker C: Come in, Helen, Emily. Take a seat. How is your research project coming along?

Speaker A: Thanks, Professor Davis. Well, we've made some good progress.

Speaker B: Yes, we had to narrow down our topic first. We originally thought about looking at microplastics in rivers, but decided that was too broad. Then we considered local recycling initiatives in our city, but we finally settled on investigating consumer attitudes toward biodegradable packaging.

Speaker C: That's a highly relevant topic. And how did you decide to gather your data?

Speaker B: We actually wanted to do laboratory tests to see how quickly different packaging materials degrade in soil. But when we spoke to the lab technician, we realized our university department simply doesn't have the necessary equipment to support that. So we opted for a survey instead, which was much more realistic.

Speaker C: Good practical thinking. And what did the survey results show?

Speaker A: We got over 200 responses. What really surprised me was that a very high percentage of people completely misidentified common eco-friendly labels on packaging. They thought certain symbols meant the packaging was home-compostable when it actually required industrial processing.

Speaker B: Yes, I expected younger consumers to be more aware of that, but the confusion was widespread across all age groups.

Speaker C: Interesting. Now, as you write up your analysis, my main advice is to avoid long paragraphs of dense text to explain your numbers. You should present your findings using visual charts. It makes the trends instantly clear to the reader.

Speaker A: That makes sense. We'll start drafting the main sections.

Speaker B: Yes, but before we write anything, don't we need to submit our research proposal for ethical approval?

Speaker C: Absolutely, Emily. You cannot start writing or conducting any further interviews until the department board signs off on your ethics form. Make that your immediate priority.

Speaker A: We'll do that this afternoon.



Speaker C: Excellent. Now, let's talk about dividing the drafting of the paper between the two of you. Who is going to write the literature review?

Speaker B: I've already compiled most of the academic sources and categorized them, so I will draft that section.

Speaker A: And since we designed the survey questionnaire together, I think it's best if we write the methodology section jointly.

Speaker B: I agree, that makes the most sense. What about the results and graphs?

Speaker A: Well, I'm quite comfortable using statistical software, so I'll take charge of generating the graphs and writing up the results section.

Speaker C: Very well. And the discussion of limitations?

Speaker B: We both noticed several limitations in our sample size, so I'll write up the draft for the discussion and limitations, and Helen can review it.

Speaker A: Perfect. And finally, for the executive summary, we should definitely write that together once the entire paper is finished so we agree on the key takeaways.

Speaker C: Sounds like a solid plan. Keep up the good work.

This is the end of Part 3.



PART 4

You will hear a university lecturer giving a talk on the historical significance and economic impact of the spice trade in the Middle Ages. You now have some time to look at questions 31 to 40.

Speaker A: Good afternoon, everyone. Today we are exploring the global commodity that shaped empires, funded voyages of discovery, and redefined culinary practices: spices. During the Middle Ages, spices were not merely culinary luxury items; they possessed profound economic and social capital. Beyond their kitchen uses, spices were heavily utilized as medicine. During times of severe epidemics, physicians believed that exotic spices could purify the air and ward off disease, making them highly sought after by the wealthy. Furthermore, certain spices were so incredibly rare and valuable that they functioned as currency. Pepper, in particular, was so precious that peppercorns were accepted as a direct payment for rents and taxes in several European cities.

Speaker A: This high value drove complex trade networks. The logistics of the spice trade were divided between sea and land. Arab and Indian merchants dominated the maritime routes. These traders crossed the Indian Ocean using traditional wooden sailing vessels known as dhows, navigating by the seasonal monsoon winds to transport cargo from India to the ports of the Red Sea. Because of the vast profits involved, the trade was characterized by strict monopolies. Merchant guilds and specific empires controlled the routes, allowing them to keep prices artificially high. Meanwhile, the overland routes, which made up parts of the famous Silk Road, were incredibly perilous. Caravans had to travel through harsh deserts and mountain passes, but the greatest threat came from bandits who regularly targeted these caravans, stealing the expensive goods and driving up the cost of security.

Speaker A: The economic and social impacts of this trade were revolutionary. First, the intense desire to bypass middlemen and find direct routes to the spice-producing islands of Asia catalyzed rapid advancements in navigation. This era saw the development of better astrolabes, more accurate mapping, and sturdier ships, launching the Age of Discovery. Economically, the spice trade concentrated massive wealth in specific hubs. In Europe, the Italian city of Venice became the richest trading center by securing exclusive trade agreements with Eastern merchants. However, European powers eventually sought direct control. A fierce conflict arose over the Banda Islands in modern-day Indonesia, which at the time were the world's sole source of nutmeg. The struggle for control of these small islands led to decades of warfare. Eventually, the extreme value of spices declined. This drop in price occurred when European nations managed to smuggle spice plants and establish domestic plantations in their own tropical colonies, breaking the old monopolies. Finally, spices also left a mark on cultural history. In medieval art, spices were frequently depicted in family portraits, representing the high social status of the household to any

viewer.

This is the end of Part 4.

